

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 39

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A girl of about nine learns, on a Sunday afternoon in an empty car park, to ride a bicycle — taught not by her father, who has given up, but by her quiet uncle.

1

The car park behind the community centre was, on Sunday afternoons, the emptiest place in the neighbourhood. The shops above it were shut. The painted lines for cars had faded into pale ghosts of themselves. It was here, on a faintly drizzling October afternoon, that I was supposed at last to learn to ride a bicycle. I was nine, and not at all sure I wanted to.

2

My father had begun the lesson with great cheerfulness and ended it, twenty minutes later, with the tight, polite expression he wore whenever something refused to go to plan. I had wobbled, screamed, slammed the brakes for no reason, and finally tipped sideways into a puddle, where I sat with the bicycle on my leg and refused to get up. He stood over me with his hands on his hips. “All right,” he said at last, in the voice of a man surrendering a long war. “All right. We will let your uncle try.”

3

My uncle was my mother’s younger brother — a slight, soft-spoken man who taught mathematics at a secondary school and seemed, to my nine-year-old eyes, to belong to a separate species from the rest of the family. He did not raise his voice. He did not even, on most occasions, raise his eyebrows. He arrived now with an umbrella and a small flask of warm barley water, neither of which I had thought to bring. He inspected the puddle, the bicycle, and me, in that order, and said only, “Shall we try again, but slowly?”

4

What followed was unlike anything my father had attempted. My uncle did not, first of all, put me on the bicycle. He made me walk it. We walked together along the painted ghost-lines for what felt like a very long time, while he asked me, in his patient way, where I thought the balance of the bicycle lived. In the handlebars? In the seat? In the wheels? I said I did not know. He said that was a sensible answer,

and that we would find out together. Only after this strange parade did he allow me to sit on the saddle, with both my feet flat on the ground, and rock slowly from side to side until I could feel — yes, actually feel — the weight of the bicycle shift beneath me.

5

Then he held the back of the saddle. I pedalled. I fell. He caught me, set me upright, said nothing in particular, and we began again. I fell a second time, and a third. After the fourth fall, when my knee began at last to bleed in a thin, businesslike line, I expected him to sigh and look at his watch, the way my father had. He did not. He took out a clean handkerchief, pressed it gently against my knee until the bleeding slowed, and asked, almost as an afterthought, whether I was tired. I said I was not. This was a lie. He nodded, as though he believed me, and we began again.

6

I cannot now say which attempt it was. Perhaps the seventh, perhaps the tenth. I remember only that I had stopped, by then, listening for his footsteps behind me. I was concentrating very hard on a single point at the far end of the car park — a green door belonging, I think, to the back of a bakery — and pedalling steadily towards it. The wind, what little there was, hummed faintly past my ears. The wheels made their small, professional clicking sound. I felt, for the first time, that the bicycle and I were not at war.

7

It was only when I reached the green door, and turned around to grin at him, that I realised my uncle was standing far behind me — perhaps thirty metres back — with his hands clasped quietly in front of him, and a smile so small that I almost missed it. He had let go. I did not know when. Five seconds, possibly more, I had ridden a bicycle entirely on my own, and had not noticed. I sat very still on the saddle, one foot on the ground, and looked at him. He looked back. Neither of us said anything for a moment. Then he raised one hand, very slightly, in a gesture that might have been a wave or might have been a salute. I waved back.

8

I have ridden a great many bicycles since then, in a great many places. But it is that quiet Sunday afternoon I still return to whenever I am asked to learn something difficult, and asked to trust someone while I learn it. My uncle, who passed away when I was at university, never once mentioned the episode again. He did not need to. I think now that the lesson he gave me that day was not really about a bicycle.

From Paragraph 1

1. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that suggest the car park was a quiet, neglected place. [2]

From Paragraph 2

2. The father's expression is described as "the tight, polite expression he wore whenever something refused to go to plan." Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about the father's character. [2]

3. The father speaks "in the voice of a man surrendering a long war." Explain what this comparison suggests about how he felt at this moment. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator says her uncle "seemed... to belong to a separate species from the rest of the family." What does this phrase suggest about how different her uncle was from her other relatives? [2]

5. Give **one** small action in Paragraph 3 that shows the uncle had come better prepared than the narrator. [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. The uncle's method is described as "unlike anything my father had attempted." Using your own words, explain **two** ways in which the uncle's method differed from her father's. [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says her knee began to bleed "in a thin, businesslike line." What is the effect of the word **businesslike** here? [2]

8. When asked if she was tired, the narrator says, "I said I was not. This was a lie." Why do you think the writer chose to add the second short sentence? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. The narrator writes that "the bicycle and I were not at war." Explain, in your own words, what this image suggests about how her relationship with the bicycle had changed. [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. In Paragraph 7, the uncle "raised one hand, very slightly, in a gesture that might have been a wave or might have been a salute." Explain how the language used in Paragraph 7 conveys the **quiet, undramatic nature** of this moment of triumph. Support your answer with **two** details from the paragraph. [3]

From Paragraph 8

11. The narrator ends the text by saying, "I think now that the lesson he gave me that day was not really about a bicycle." What does she mean by this? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the worldwide rise of childhood short-sightedness, why scientists now believe sunlight is the missing factor, and what schools and families can do about it.

1

A century ago, a child who could not read the blackboard from the back of a classroom was an uncommon sight. Today, in many parts of the world, such a child is the rule rather than the exception. Short-sightedness — known to ophthalmologists as **myopia** — has spread among children at a pace that few public-health problems can match. In Seoul, almost ninety-six per cent of nineteen-year-old men are now myopic. In Singapore, roughly two thirds of children are myopic by the end of primary school. In China, urban schoolyards routinely produce classes in which nearly every child wears glasses by the age of twelve. The numbers are no longer remarkable. They are, in some places, the new normal.

2

For most of the twentieth century, the standard explanation was straightforward: children read too much, sat too close to their books, and, more recently, stared too long at screens. Parents the world over have repeated the warning. Sit up straight. Hold the book further away. Put down the phone. It is an explanation that feels intuitive, and it has the comforting property of placing the blame on something the family can, in principle, control. Unfortunately, when researchers began to examine the evidence in the early 2000s, the picture turned out to be more complicated than the conventional wisdom suggested.

3

A series of large studies, beginning with a comparison of Chinese children in Singapore and Australia, found something striking. Children of similar genetic background, doing similar amounts of reading and homework, developed myopia at very different rates depending on where they grew up. The single factor that best explained the difference was not the hours spent on books or screens. It was, of all things, the hours spent **outdoors**. Children who spent at least two hours a day in natural daylight were considerably less likely to become short-sighted than those who did not, regardless of how much reading they did indoors. Bright outdoor light, scientists now believe, triggers the release of a chemical in the eye that helps the eyeball grow in its proper, healthy shape.

4

The discovery shifted the debate. If the missing ingredient was sunlight, then the place to act was the school day, where most of a child's waking hours are spent. In Taiwan, the education ministry mandated in 2010 that primary schools schedule a minimum of eighty minutes of outdoor time per day, including recess. Within a few years, the proportion of new myopia cases among schoolchildren began, for the first time in decades, to fall. Singapore followed with its own **“Read Outdoors”** and **“Outdoor Recess”** initiatives, and several pilot schools have reported measurable improvements. The lesson appears to be that the cure, or at least the prevention, may be as simple — and as politically awkward — as making children spend less time at their desks.

5

For children whose eyesight has already begun to worsen, technology now offers two further interventions. The first is **orthokeratology**, the wearing of specially shaped contact lenses overnight that gently reshape the cornea while the child sleeps. The lenses are removed each morning, and the child enjoys clear vision through the day. The second is the use of low-dose **atropine** eye drops, which slow the elongation of the eyeball during the growth years. Trials in Singapore, in particular, have shown that a very dilute form of atropine reduces the progression of myopia by about half in children aged six to twelve, with few troublesome side effects. Neither treatment is a cure; both, however, can keep a child's prescription from becoming severe enough to threaten future eye health.

6

None of this changes the fact that families remain the front line. Specialists offer broadly the same practical advice. Encourage at least one to two hours of daylight outdoor activity each day, even on cloudy days, since outdoor light is far brighter than indoor lighting. Apply the so-called “twenty-twenty-twenty” rule during close work: every twenty minutes, look at something twenty feet away for at least twenty seconds. Keep screens and books at a sensible distance and in well-lit rooms. And, most importantly, take a child for an eye check before any worrying symptoms appear, since early prescription glasses and follow-up treatment can make a substantial difference to long-term outcomes.

7

Whether the tide of childhood myopia can be turned remains to be seen. The condition, once it has begun, is difficult to reverse, and severe myopia in adulthood carries small but real risks of more serious eye disease later in life. Yet the discoveries of the last two decades have, for the first time, given parents and schools something they did not previously possess: a clear and surprisingly low-tech answer. Open the windows. Open the doors. Send the children outside.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that the numbers “are no longer remarkable. They are, in some places, the new normal.” Explain, in your own words, what the writer means by this. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **one** reason why the traditional explanation for myopia (too much reading, screens, etc.) has been so popular with parents. [1]

14. The writer describes the traditional explanation as having “the comforting property of placing the blame on something the family can, in principle, control.” What does this phrase suggest about **why** such explanations appeal to families? [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. According to Paragraph 3, which factor best explained the difference in myopia rates between Chinese children growing up in Singapore and those growing up in Australia? [1]

16. Explain, in your own words, **how** sunlight is believed to help prevent short-sightedness, according to Paragraph 3. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that the cure “may be as simple — and as politically awkward — as making children spend less time at their desks.” Explain why the cure might be considered **politically awkward**. [2]

18. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 4 which suggests that the Taiwanese policy of mandating outdoor time has worked. [1]

From Paragraph 5

19. According to Paragraph 5, explain, in your own words, how **orthokeratology** helps a child see clearly during the day. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer advises that outdoor activity should happen “even on cloudy days.” Why, according to the text, does this advice still make sense? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the text with three short sentences: “Open the windows. Open the doors. Send the children outside.” What is **effective** about ending the article in this way? [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **what causes children to become short-sighted** and **what can be done in schools, in clinics, and at home to prevent or slow the condition**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Research now suggests that childhood short-sightedness is caused mainly by ...

— END OF PAPER —